

SSL and the Art of Encryption

One of the major hurdles for online shopping is the issue of a secure system, which promises the users that they are in safe hands and their credit cards wouldn't be misused.

Many of the e-commerce sites provide for secure transactions, using encryption technology to protect your credit-card number. You can verify that you have entered a secured transaction when you see 'https:// ' at the beginning of the URL instead of 'http:// ' and the SSL security icon (a closed lock) at the bottom of your browser.

The higher the bit-depth of the encryption technology used, the more secure is the transaction. For instance, 128-bit encryption provides a significantly greater amount of cryptographic protection than 40-bit encryption.

According to security experts, 128-bit encryption is a very strong and secure method of encryption—even if someone tries to break into the security it would take him innumerable man-years of effort to break in.

However, even though we have industry experts shouting at the top of their voices, assuring people that credit-card numbers are safer online than they would be in any local restaurant or store, it's a natural tendency for people not to part with valuable information and it will definitely take some time to change this mindset. As a work-around many sites offer accept alternate forms of payment, such as through cheque, DD or cash on delivery.



Countryoven eases your gift giving dilemmas

Do not get taken in by the name though, as this site isn't just about oven fresh cookies or other scrumptious goodies. It is, in fact, one of the most comprehensive sites where you will find almost all products ranging from chocolate chip cookies to high-end electronic gizmos neatly categorised.

In addition, the site provides you with services such as birthday reminders via e-mail. You can also get status information regarding your gift by simply typing in your order number. And if you are a bit jumpy about what kind of gifts to send to who, then relax and let the 'gift finder' do the dirty work for you.

The site is easy to navigate and has gifts categorised according to various occasions. The site also has a WAP enabled version at <http://giftagift.com/wap> (however, you could have some problems accessing it).

Another site that has been around for a long time is www.homeindia.com. This site was the cynosure of all eyes when it won the coveted prize for the most useful Web site, given by *The Economic Times* back in 1998.

With a strong backend and a dedicated logistics team, the site ensures that your product is delivered as promised. Since the site is also listed with the Consumer Protection Association of America (CPAA), you can freely lodge a complaint with this apex body if you find any discrepancies in the site's performance regarding delivery.

The online counterpart of the popular chain of retail gift stores, www.archiesonline.com is a site where you can gather loyalty points while shopping, which you can later redeem. The site also has a reminder and scheduler section where you can enter important dates and receive reminders accordingly.

The customise page option, called the 'My Archies page', helps you organise all the above. While this is a good enough site for shopping, it could do with better graphics to spruce up the

homepage display.

Another site worth a look is www.rediff.com, which is a portal with a difference—apart from the latest in news, it has a section for all you shopaholics. Login at <http://shopping.rediff.com/> and choose from amongst a decent collection of national and international brands. The site is easily navigable as it has well-categorised items.

For instance, the Books section has categories such as Readers Choice, New Arrivals, Best Sellers, Rediff Recommends, etc. Any queries that you might have can be directed at the site's customer help line that can be reached by phone, e-mail, toll free line and even online chat. While at the site, glance through their Hot Sellers and Popular Picks sections, as also the Maha Offers section, where you can find some interesting bargains.

The site also offers you a flexible mode of payment through cheque, demand draft, cash on delivery or even Internet banking. Being a Verisign-certified site makes all the difference, as it ensures that your transactions are secure, with the help of SSL (Standard Sockets Layer) encryption.

While not quite in the league of a giant such as Amazon, www.fabmart.com is a neat site with good navigation features and a good range of products that are well arranged and easy to identify.



Fabmart.com: A fab product range

The book lovers amongst you will find the site's collection, ranging from *Amar Chitra Katha* to the latest releases quite good, but what's more interesting is that if the site fails to deliver certain purchases by a certain time, it will not charge for that shipment.

And even if you are not looking for gifts to buy but are interested in more mundane things like groceries, Fabmart takes care of that too. So you can choose from cheese spreads to jams and